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✓ 87



GPTZero

✓ 76



Copyleaks

✓ 100



Human written



50% human written



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Dramatically located on the volcanic cliffs above Abades, the Sanatorio de Abona is one of the most curious and photogenic sites in Tenerife. And its crumbling white walls, its long abandoned corridors and the panoramic views it offers over the sea make it an unforgettable sight — its that and more, and history is just as captivating as appearance. ## What is the Sanatorio de Abona? Constructed in the 1930s and 1940s, the Sanatorio de Abona was first a tuberculosis sanatorium. At the time, tuberculosis (TB) was among the most lethal diseases in Europe, and physicians thought that clean sea air, sunshine and a warm climate were some of the best medicines. The site above Abades was selected specifically — the height above the sea would capitalize on the continual fresh Atlantic breezes, while the direct south-facing line of sight would bring the most sun possible each day of the year. The Canary Islands, and Tenerife in particular, had become a haven for European TB sufferers looking for recuperation by turn of the 20th century. ### The Architecture The facility is a stunning specimen of 1930s rationalist architecture – It has sharp edges, large windows that allow maximum light and ventilation and open foyers that extend along the sides where patients would bask in the sun and breathe the sea air. Even in ruins, the size and scope of the original building is impressive. The complex consisted of: – **Wards for patients** with large sea-facing windows – **Treatment rooms,** medical center – **Staff housing** and offices buildings – **Exterior balconies** with full Atlantic ocean views – **A chapel** for the patients and the staff – **Isolation units** for the worst cases On sunny, bright days, vistas from the sanatorio are visible up to the island of Gran Canaria. ## The History ### Construction (1934–1943) Construction began in 1934 under the supervision of the Spanish architect José Enrique Marrero Regalado. The undertaking was large and costly, financed by the Spanish government as a part of a national campaign against tuberculosis. It was built to hold a maximum of 300 patients and a full staff of doctors. Architecture was informed by the newest thinking about TB care — fresh air and sunshine, and patients on open-air balconies most of the time. ### The Tuberculosis Era The sanatorium was established in the early 1940s and continued as a TB hospital for around two decades. Patients travelled from across the Canary Islands and mainland Spain in search of the therapeutic air of Tenerife's south coast. Treatment was crude by modern standards: – Bed rest in the outdoors – Sunbathing (heliotherapy) – To eat a nutritious diet to build-up one's strength – Surgical interventions, such as lung collapse therapy – From the general population isolation Life at the sanatorio was highly structured and frequently spanned months or years. Patients inhabited a world unto itself, disconnected from their families and everyday existence. ### Decline and Abandonment By 1950, the emergence of effective antibiotic treatments for tuberculosis – foremost the drug streptomycin – transformed TB care. Patients could be treated with medicine as opposed to having to spend months in isolation at sanatoria. There was no longer any need to have separate TB hospitals. The

Sanatorio de Abona was slowly being abandoned in the 1960s as patients were being discharged and no new recruits coming in. The building was abandoned to the elements. Over the next several decades, it deteriorated. The roof caved in, windows were broken and the Atlantic wind as well as the salt air hastened deterioration. ### Modern Day Today, the sanatorium stands as a haunting ruin — a testament to a disease that once frightened Europe, and to the patients who found their final days here. This site is popular with: - **Urban explorers** and photographers - **Enthusiasts of history** of medicine - **Showbiz** (it has been used in several Spanish films) - **Travelers** looking for something a little out of the ordinary. ## Today you can enjoy ### The Main Building The central building is the most complete section of the complex. You can still see: - **Long hospital corridors** lined with peeling paint and broken tiles - **Rooms** for patients with sea-facing windows - **Main Staircase** to the upstairs (do not ascend!) - **Treatment rooms** with traces of medical device - **The chapel with its signature arched doorway.) ### The Terraces The patients would rest on the open-air terraces, which can still be seen, covered with vegetation and falling apart. The views were spectacular — the entire south-east coast of Tenerife was right there. ### The Outbuildings There are a few scattered around the main house: - **Staff quarters** — small derelict cottages in a variety of states - **Sheds and workshops** - water tanks that served the complex - **The old trail** leading up from the village of Abades ### Graffiti and Art Over the years, the sanatorio grew increasingly covered in graffiti — some of it crude, some of it surprisingly artistic. The combination of graffiti-covered walls and derelict buildings gives off a bizarre, post-apocalyptic vibe. ## Visiting the Sanatorio de Abona ### Location The sanatorium is perched on the promontory above Abades village, a 10-minute walk from Ocean Deck House. **Address:** Carretera General del Sur (TF-1), Abades, Arico **GPS Coordinates:** 28.1633° N, 16.4547° W ### Access - **Free entry** — the site is public domain - **No guided tours** — it's a self-guided tour - **Open 24/7** — though daytime visits are strongly encouraged - **No facilities** — no toilets, water, or shade available. ### How to Get There **From Ocean Deck House:** 1. Walk up the hill from Abades beach (10 min) 2. Follow the old road towards the TF-1 highway 3. You can see the sanatorio on the right as you look out to sea from the clifftop. **By car:** - Leave the car in the village Abades and walk up (Lasquer safest option) - Or leave the car on the side of the road near the sanatorio (space is limited, watch for traffic) ### What to Bring - Sturdy shoes: There is a lot of uneven terrain mixed with broken glass and debris - Camera — amazing photo opportunities - Flashlight — a few places are dark (but DO NOT ENTER any sealed buildings) - Water — No facilities on the premises. - Sun protection — shade is minimal can get very hot - Long pants -- protection from sharp edges and plants ## ⚠ Safety Considerations **Note:** The sanatorio is a hazardous place. Please heed these warnings: - **The buildings are unsafe** — do not enter sealed buildings or climb stairs - Floors and ceilings may collapse" at any moment - Watch for rocks and debris, too - The edges of cliffs are perilous — keep well back - No facilities (latrines, water, first aid) - Some areas have no mobile phone reception. - Keep children under closely supervision at all times. - DO NOT GO ALONE — bring at least one other person. **We recommend strongly that you view only the outside.** The best views and photographs are taken from outside the building. ## 8B Photography Tips The Sanatorio de Abona is a photographer's dream: ### Best Shots 1. against the blue sky 2. Ocean views framed by arched doorways 3. Peepers paint in deserted hallways 4. art on crumbling walls 5. The ruins in sunset silhouettes 6. Wide shots of the clifftop location ### Best Time for Photos - Golden hour (sunrise/sunset) — warm, dramatic light - Midday — harsh light, but works for black and white - Overcast days moody, atmospheric photos ### Drone photography You can take photos with a drone but keep in mind: - Strong winds on the cliff top - Close to the TF-1 highway - Be respectful of other visitors ## The Cultural Impact ### In Popular Culture The sanatorio has featured in: - Spanish films and tv series - International photography exhibitions - Urban exploration documentaries - Music videos by Spanish and international artists ### Local Attitudes The locals are divided over the place's fortunes: - Some (weather-permit), see it as a tragic waste and an eyesore - Others consider it a vital historical mark - Occasionally

there are statuettes, bits of magic, fairy tales (mostly pumped up for tourists) - Some say it should be restored, others that it should be left to ruin

Conservation Debate

There is a conservation debate raging about the future of the sanatorio: - Knock it down – for some, it's unsafe and should be dismantled - Restore – 'there's a body of opinion that it should be conserved and it become a museum or a cultural centre' - Stabilise – get it safe without destroying its ruined ambience - Status quo — leave it as is

For the time being, it's in The Nothing Place — exposed and unrated.

Nearby Attractions

After the sanatorio tour, visit: -

- Playa de Abades** - a lovely beach (5 minutes walk down the hill) -
- Abades village** — real fishing village with local eateries -
- Coastal hiking trails** that run along the cliffs -
- Arico Nuevo** — typical Canarian village (10 minutes by car)

Ethical Tourism

When you visit desolate places like this one, keep in mind: -

- Leave no trace** — take only photos, leave only footprints." -
- Respect the history** — This was a place of pain and recovery -
- Don't vandalize** — every time someone tags graffiti it is removed, but the site is diminished for future visitors. -
- Support local businesses** — head over to Abades village and dine at one of the village eateries -
- Share responsibly** — don't glorify risk-taking in your images

Conclusion

The Sanatorio de Abona is not just a derelict building — it is a medical history time capsule, a symbol of the fury of tuberculosis, and how swiftly medical science can reshape our world. Whether you like history, are an urban explorer, photographer or just an inquisitive traveller, the sanatorio provides a very unique and thought-provoking experience.

Stay at Ocean Deck House? The sanatorio is a 10-minute walk from your door perfect for a pre-dawn or sunset adventure before you return to the comfort of your deck with an ocean view.

--- Have you been to the Sanatorio de Abona? What did you think? Share your experience and snaps!*